

Newly released documents reveal more than \$300,000 in taxpayer-funded sexual harassment settlements involving lawmakers

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Taxpayers have paid more than \$300,000 in confidential sexual harassment settlements on behalf of six former members of the House of Representatives or their offices, according to GOP Rep. Nancy Mace and documents reviewed by CNN.

The Office of Congressional Workplace Rights was compelled to turn over the settlement documents to Congress following a subpoena from Mace, who has helped lead an effort on Capitol Hill to push for transparency and accountability following sexual misconduct allegations that led to a pair of [high-profile resignations](#).

A CNN review of over 1,000 pages of case files, including counsel notes, settlement documents and formal complaints, offers a window into allegations that certain members leveraged their positions of power to mistreat their staff.

The Office of Congressional Workplace Rights is involved with a range of complaints against members, not exclusively sexual harassment claims.

From January 1, 1996, through December 12, 2018, the office approved 349 awards or settlements “to resolve complaints against legislative branch offices,” its general counsel said in a letter sent to House Oversight Chair James Comer obtained by CNN. Eighty of those cases were settled by a House or Senate office for a host of different reasons. From that subset, seven cases led to payments to address allegations of sexual harassment. The payments referenced in the letter used taxpayer money from a Treasury account that no longer exists as an option for lawmakers.

Twenty-three case files of settlements in the jurisdiction of the Office of Congressional Workplace Rights were destroyed pursuant to the office’s record retention policy.

“This ‘OCWR Record Retention Policy’ was put in place in 2013 to align OCWR with regular government-wide record retention practices,” General Counsel John N. Ohlweiler wrote.

The general language of the settlement contracts reviewed by CNN do not have the accused office admitting to any wrongdoing, but rather state the office is agreeing to the settlement “to avoid the inconvenience of protracted litigation and the expense to the parties and the taxpayers of such litigation,” as one settlement read. The settlement agreements also lay out how the office is meant to handle questions related to the terms or conditions of the claimant’s termination of employment.

Following policy changes made in 2018 in the wake of the #MeToo Movement, members could no longer rely on taxpayer dollars for settlements. The House Ethics Committee announced in a recent

statement that since the enactment of the new law, “the Committee has not been notified of any awards or settlements relating to allegations of sexual harassment by a member.”

Mace named six former lawmakers or lawmakers’ offices involved in the settlements totaling more than \$300,000 in an X post on Monday. Most of the members named by the congresswoman resigned from Congress after publicly facing allegations of sexual misconduct, including former Reps. John Conyers, a Michigan Democrat, and Blake Farenthold, a Texas Republican.

In several of these cases, it was publicly reported prior to their resignations that the member had used taxpayer funds for settlements.

CNN has attempted to reach out to either the former member or a representative for all six members named by Mace. Three of the former lawmakers named by the congresswoman, including Conyers and Farenthold, are deceased.

In 2017, the House Ethics Committee launched an investigation into Conyers, who at the time [denied](#) any wrongdoing, but did not dispute the existence of a settlement or payment. The documents show that a severance payment of over \$27,000 and another \$50,000 settlement payment were made on behalf of Conyers.

Farenthold [resigned](#) the same year, in 2018, while also facing an ethics probe. He denied some of the allegations against him, but apologized for using inappropriate language and his role in creating a hostile workplace and vowed to repay taxpayer money used for a settlement. The documents show that an \$84,000 settlement was made on Farenthold’s behalf.

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